

As it would be palpably absurd to load these pages with the technicalities of the chief justice's decisions, the relation of which belongs more to a history of the law than of its administration, it will be enough for us to refer those who are interested in them to the Reports of Richard Bellewe, who, in 1585, published a collection of the cases decided in the reign of Richard II. No complaint appears to have been made against his judicial conduct in civil matters; but in his political career he was not so fortunate. Instead of using the influence of his position to check the royal extravagance and folly, he became, by countenancing whatever was agreeable to the king, a favourite at court, and a partisan of Robert de Vere, Duke of Ireland.¹ This nobleman's ascendancy over the youthful monarch was so great, that, according to Froissart, "if he had sayd, sir, this is whyte, though it had ben blacke, the kynge wolde nat have sayd the contrarye." The effect of this misplaced confidence was soon visible in the disordered state of the revenue, and the adoption of unpopular taxes to supply its deficiencies. Not only did the people murmur, but the houses of parliament found it necessary to put a stop to the maladministration of de Vere and his associates.

One of these, the Chancellor de la Pole, was impeached in the first instance; and his conviction was followed by a statute placing the management of the state and the control of the revenue in the hands of eleven permanent commissioners, at the head of whom were the king's uncles, the Dukes of York and Gloucester. Although this commission was solemnly confirmed by the king's letters patent, dated

¹ Lord Campbell says, that he owed his appointment as chief justice to the influence of de Vere; but there is nothing to support this statement. De Vere, then Earl of Oxford, was only about fifteen when Tresilian was raised to the bench, nineteen when he was made chief justice, and was not created Duke of Ireland till six years afterwards.